

PE firms don't hire hope. They deploy operators.

By Jason Rigolli — Founder, Revved for Growth · <https://fixyourrevenueengine.com/insights/pe-firms-deploy-operators/>

TL;DR. Two companies hit the same flat quarter. The portfolio company deploys a proven operator and fixes its engine in a quarter; the founder-led company opens a search for a sales leader and waits a year to find out if the guess was right. PE firms don't hire hope, they deploy operators, and the fund's real advantage was never capital, it was the bench. Founders don't have a bench, but it is rentable: a fractional operator carries variable comp tied to outcomes and an engagement you can end in a quarter, so skin exists on both sides. Because managing a working engine is far easier to staff than building one, rent the builder first, then hire the manager. It starts with a Revenue Engine Inspection: a structured look under the hood before you spend another dollar on headcount, agencies, or hope.

Two companies hit the same wall in the same month.

The first is a portfolio company. Flat quarter, pipeline thinning, forecast wobbling. The operating partner reads the report, makes one call, and an operator is inside the building by month's end. Not a candidate. Not a search. An operator with dozens of revenue engines behind them, scoped to fix this one and leave.

The second is a founder-led company. Same flat quarter, same thinning pipeline. The founder does what founders are taught to do: hire a sales leader. Recruiter fees, ninety days of interviews, six months of ramp, and a coin-flip's odds the hire fits. A year from now the founder will know if they guessed right. The portfolio company's engine got fixed in one quarter.

Same problem. Two playbooks.

PE firms don't hire hope. They deploy operators.

Before you read this as an ad for private equity: it isn't. You don't need a fund to steal their best move. The fund's advantage was never the capital... it's the bench. Proven operators they drop into an underperforming company to name the problem, fix it, and hand it back running. The full-time hire happens after, when they know what the seat actually requires... and the operator just wrote the job description.

Founders don't have a bench. But the bench is rentable.

The obvious objection: doesn't a fractional operator lack skin in the game? Look at how these engagements actually get structured. Fractional operators... fractional CROs especially... carry variable comp tied to the outcomes they move: revenue, milestones, trajectory. And the engagement can end in a quarter, at your call, no severance. A salaried executive has variable comp too, plus a guaranteed base, a ramp you wait through, and an exit that costs you. Skin exists on both sides. The difference is who holds the downside.

And notice what the question assumes: that you already know what the seat needs. Three flat quarters in, you don't. Hiring a permanent executive to diagnose your engine is paying a captain's salary for a mechanic's job... and if the diagnosis is wrong, you've now got two problems and one of them has equity.

Here's the asymmetry nobody prices in: it is far easier to find someone to manage a working engine than to find someone who can fix or build one. Builders are rare. Managers are plentiful, cheaper, and easier to vet... once there's a working engine to hand them.

So rent the builder. Then hire the manager.

What does deploying look like at founder scale? An operator embedded in your business a few days a week, accountable for naming the real problem, fixing it alongside the team you already have, and writing the job description for the manager who takes it over. The engagement ends. The engine keeps running.

It starts with a diagnostic. Mine is called the Revenue Engine Inspection... a structured look under the hood that tells you what the engine actually needs before you spend another dollar on headcount, agencies, or hope.

The fund makes one call. [So can you.](#)



About the author — Jason Rigolli

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Jason Rigolli fixes the reason a company isn't hitting its number. A two-time co-founder with three CRO seats and over two decades rebuilding revenue engines, he works inside founder-led, family-owned, and PE-backed B2B firms (\$2M-\$15M) across winning, keeping, and growing customers.

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